EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Did God Create the World? Space, Time and Purpose

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 1:4

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 1 (Creation), Chapter 4: the questions people ask about creation (questions 3 to 10), completing Essay 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 20 May 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Essay 1 So Far

Essay 1 has been about **the creation of the universe**: not yet **who** created it (that is Essay 2, "Hashem, next time"), and not yet **what Hashem wants from us** (the later essays).

Chapter	What Rav Saadia established
1-2	Three premises: **there was a beginning**; it came **from something external**; and it was **from nothing**
3	**Twelve rival theories** of how the world came to be, each refuted, "some of them nowadays logically we consider nonsensical," studied over the past few weeks
4	Now that we know there is a Creator, **ten questions** people ask

The first two questions (last week)

#	Question	Rav Saadia's answer
1	Kohelet) **דור הלך ודור בא והארץ לעולם עמדת** a generation goes and a generation comes, :(1:4 **and the earth stands forever**. Doesn't that imply ?the earth is eternal	Everything on earth is constantly renewed, and **so was the earth**: it too came into being. The verse means that **relative to** the humans, animals and plants on it, the earth is **relatively** constant
2	**How** can anyone create something from nothing?	**If you knew, you would be the Creator yourself.** This is precisely one of the differences between us and God: He can create from nothing and we cannot, so our faculties cannot grasp how

Tonight: the remaining eight, on **space, time, and the reason for creation**.

Question 3: What Was There Before, in Space?

A person thinks about the place where the earth now is, and asks: **what was in that space before the earth was created?**

"Remember, all of these questions are based on the fact that Saadia has now proven there's a beginning. If you hold the world is eternal, there's nothing to ask: the space was always occupied."

The class tried: "**A void**." Another: "**Godliness** filled that space." Rav Saadia goes further: **there is no question at all**.

If you ask this, **you have not understood what place is.** You imagine place as **something underneath that holds things**. But then you would have to ask what holds that place, and what holds *that*, without end. **Place is where two physical bodies meet.** When there are no physical things, **the concept of place does not apply.**

***HaMakom*: "He is the place of the world"**

"This is the depth of what the Hachamim say." Why do we call Hashem **המקום, *HaMakom*, the Place**, as in **ברוך המקום ברוך הוא** in the Haggadah?

הוא מקומו של עולם ואין עולמו מקומו. He is the place of the world; the world is not His place.

"Our brains don't always understand this, but let's repeat it. We think of the world as God's place. That's the wrong way round. **He is the *makom* of the world.**" When there is nothing physical, there is only godliness, and no "place" to ask about.

The gematria of *Makom*

The Rabbi recalled something taught long ago, in the series on Yichud Hashem:

	Letters	Value
The Name	י ה ו ה	10 + 5 + 6 + 5 = **26**
מקום	מ ק ו ם	40 + 100 + 6 + 40 = **186**
The Name, each letter squared	$10^2 + 5^2 + 6^2 + 5^2$	100 + 25 + 36 + 25 = **186**

Why we comfort mourners with *HaMakom*. We say **המקום ינחם אתכם**, may *HaMakom* comfort you. When a loved one dies, "that's the time when it's most difficult to recognise *Yichud Hashem*. Such a bad thing has happened." So we pray that the Name will be **squared**: that Hashem's presence will be **fully manifested and expressed in the world**. "You now only see something bad. But when Hashem's name is squared and His presence is manifest in the world, that will console you, because then you'll see the presence of Hashem in the world."

Question 4: What Was There Before, in Time?

Whenever the world was created (Rav Saadia will say about 4,000 years before his day; we would say over 5,000, or 15 billion years, "whatever it may be"), **how was there time, with no sun and no moon?**

The class answered well: (a) **nothing was measuring time** without sun or moon; and (b) "**time is relative**, it's not absolute"; "**time is a creation**, when the world is created."

Rav Saadia: you ask this only if you think **time is something external to the universe**, constantly running on and on, with the world inside it. That is not how time works. **When there are no created things, there is no time.**

"This is an important principle which he's going to reiterate later on as well: **time is relative to the things that are in it.**" So the question *what was Hashem doing before He created the world?* does not begin.

"It's very difficult for us to think in these terms. Our lives are dominated by time. Yes, within the physical realm. But once we leave the physical realm, there is no time."

So far: without creation there is **no specific place** (question 3) and **no specific time** (question 4).

Question 5: Is This All the Creator Could Make?

A person looks around and asks: **is this all the wisdom of the Creator?** Just the earth and the sky?

The Rabbi set the question in its time: in the 900s "all you have really is the earth and the heavens," and not even all of the earth. "It doesn't know about America, it doesn't know about Australia. All you have is Asia, Africa and a bit of Europe."

Rav Saadia's answer: Hashem created **as much as we are able to grasp**, enough for us to recognise His wisdom. He would not create what we could not take in.

"I think that fits in very beautifully. As our scientific understanding grows, so does our understanding of **how vast the universe is**." Thousands, probably millions, of planets; our one planet in one galaxy, the Milky Way, among millions of others. "Nowadays we'd say there's no such question. On the contrary: this is incredible, the wisdom of Hashem."

Question 6: Did He Create All of It?

Is there any part of the universe that Hashem **did not** create?

No. When we say Hashem created the universe, we do not mean He created *some* of it. **He created all of it, entirely.**

Question 7: Is the World Only 4,693 Years Old?

How can you accept that the world is **only 4,693 years old**?

That number dates the writing: by the reckoning of the time (Adam created on day six), 4,693 years from creation puts Rav Saadia **writing this book in 933 CE**.

His answer: whenever the beginning was, *someone* would be living at a given distance from it.

"Imagine we were created **a hundred years after the universe**. Would we ask, how can the world only be a hundred years old, so therefore it can't be the beginning? No, of course not." There is **no benchmark**. If you would not ask it after 100 years, why ask it after 4,693? "There was a beginning. Whether it's 4,000, whether it's 100, whether it's 6,000 or 16 million years, doesn't really make a difference."

The modern question

A participant noted that Rav Saadia had no **carbon dating**, no scientists saying a bone is fifteen million years old. "Yes. There's a whole different question which Saadia of course never dreamt of": **how do we reconcile the Torah's account with a universe that seems to be millions or billions of years old?** The Rabbi had given a class on this six or seven years earlier and summarised some approaches:

Approach	Idea
The Flood	After the *mabul* of Noach things changed completely, including radioactive dating
Long days	The six days were much longer. "Remember, we said **time is a creation**," together with the sun and moon. How do you measure hours on days one and two?
Adam as the completed human	*The Rabbi's preferred explanation* (below)

Adam: "the pinnacle of humanity, the completed article."

When the Torah says that on day six Hashem created man, it means **the completed man as we know him**, the final **Homo sapiens**. As science tells us, that man had many ancestors, "the Neanderthals and all those that came before him," which over millions of years became the sophisticated *adam*. Then Hashem **breathed into him the *nishmat chayim***: "Until now you were a kind of mammal developing. Now we're going to give you **the ability to choose between good and bad**."

That is why Bereshit chapter 2 stresses that only when the *neshamah* was blown into him did **ויהי האדם לנפש חיה** happen. "That's the human whom the Torah is directed to. The Torah is not directed to the incomplete humans before that."

Is there a contradiction with keeping Shabbat every seven days? Someone once asked the Rabbi: if the days were millions of years, Shabbat should come every few million years. "No. At the end of the day the Torah still calls it **a period of evening and morning, *yom echad***. So we keep that pattern every seventh day." But clearly it was not 24-hour days "because there's no sun." It was a process, "and if you want to include evolution in that, so be it. I don't find a problem with that, **provided you see HaKadosh Baruch Hu as the progenitor of everything and the mind behind it all**, completing with the pinnacle of creation."

Discussion. One participant said they had always given that kind of answer, but when they asked **Dr Gerald Schroeder** (author of a well-known book on the subject), he told them it was "absolutely wrong" and should not be taught. They offered another: that Hashem **created and destroyed many worlds** before this one. The Rabbi found that it "doesn't sit comfortably with science" either: "What did He destroy? If artifacts of the previous worlds remain, how much did He destroy?" He added that he personally does not find the question difficult: "I really see the creation narrative fitting in very beautifully with the development of humanity." The participant replied that it is very hard to convince a non-believer. "To convince people is something else. **We always need to understand things in our own terms before we can explain them to others.** There's no proof of it. It's a way to reconcile."

Question 8: Was Not Creating an Act?

"I'm not fully clear on this one. I'll do my best to explain it."

When a person **has the ability** to do something and **abstains**, we consider that abstention **a kind of action**: "I've made a conscious decision not to do it." Hashem left things uncreated until He created them. So was He **actively abstaining** before creation?

Rav Saadia's answer, as the Rabbi understood it: again, **you are applying human terms to God**. For humans, every choice has an opposite: if you don't want something you are against it; if you don't hate, you love. With Hashem we do not say that because He did not create, He *wanted not* to create.

Questions 9 and 10: Why Create? And Why Then?

"Now he comes to the big question." Rav Saadia **throws it in right at the end of the whole essay**: **why did Hashem create the universe at all?**

"In the Torah and the Talmud there is never any discussion of why Hashem created the world. It's fascinating when you think about it. **Saadia is the very first Jewish philosopher to ask this question in writing**, only about a thousand years ago."

Three answers

#	Rav Saadia's answer	The Rabbi's comment
1	**Without a purpose.** *But humans never act without a purpose; someone who does is wasting his time!* That is because **humans** act for goals and ends. **Godliness is elevated above this.**	In short: He created for a reason **we do not know**. "Not very convincing," at first sight
2	**To show His great wisdom**	"I don't really like it. It means you have this Creator who wants to show off His universe." To whom, if nobody yet existed? Perhaps only if we are meant to **learn from His characteristics and develop**
3	**For the good of His creatures**, so that they can serve Him and be **rewarded**, and be guided by Him: **אני ה' אלהיך מלמדך להועיל מדריכך בדרך תלך** (Yeshayahu 48:17), I am Hashem your God who teaches you for your benefit, who guides you in the way you should go	"The one we understand well"

"The answers contradict each other," the Rabbi noted. "You can't say He created it for no reason and then give a reason." So these are **three distinct options**, and the third is the one people can most readily hold on to.

The Rambam: no question to ask

The class guessed the Rambam would choose the third answer. In fact he goes with **the first**. The Rabbi read from the **Moreh Nevuchim (3:13)**:

"Intelligent persons are perplexed when they inquire into the purpose of the Creation..." **An agent acting with intention** has a purpose, and what is produced with intention has passed from non-existence into existence. But a being whose existence is absolute, who never was and never will be without existence, **needs no agent**, and **"what is the purpose?" can only be asked of what is the product of an agent.**

"We ask *why did he do this, why did she do that, what's the motive*, all the time. Because we think in those terms, we get stuck." For both Rav Saadia's first answer and the Rambam: **there is no question.** "You're only asking because you're a human, and therefore an agent, and you expect things to have purposes. That's not the way things work with God." It is hard for us to accept, "because our minds always think of cause and effect, purpose and goal," but both Rav Saadia and the Rambam are content with it, "and therefore we have to be willing to think about this answer."

Discussion: belief, science and the polemic

- One participant argued that, in today's world, **every schoolchild could challenge the science** behind these arguments: "You have to work with belief." There was nothing; God was there; He created. "If you don't believe, all the explanations are challengeable."
- Another participant asked: wasn't Emunot VeDeot a **polemic** against those who claimed Islam had superseded Judaism, and how was it received? "It definitely was," the Rabbi said, though not only against Islam: the twelve theories included Plato and Hindu schools. How the outside world received this particular answer: "I actually don't know."
- A participant recalled the midrash that **Hashem looked into the Torah as a blueprint** and created the world. "It says that clearly," the Rabbi agreed, "100 percent. But that's about how, not about why He created it."

The Ramchal: the depth of the third answer

The way the question is usually presented today, the Rabbi said, is **the Ramchal's**, which develops Rav Saadia's third answer (as those who studied **Derech Hashem** together will remember):

God is good, and the nature of the good is to bestow good. He wants to bestow **perfect** good, which is **Himself**. The best way is for human beings to **choose good themselves**, and so **become good**, which is the closest you can get to God, and enjoy His goodness.

A participant pushed back: what is "good"? With technology (he cited the book ***Deep Utopia***) we may soon have no hunger or want, and then what would charity or helping others mean? And how many people are truly working on themselves? The Rabbi answered that good is **two things**: **character**, working on yourself ("you don't get angry"), as well as acts of goodness. "That's what we're doing with the Sefirat HaOmer every day." And: "I still think humans deep down want to work on themselves and become better people."

Question 10: why at that moment?

Whichever the reason, why did He create when He did, and not earlier?

Answer	
There is no time with God	"To ask why 15 billion years ago and not 16, or 100, or 200 billion, there's no such question, because there is no concept of time"
A free agent chooses	That is how one who chooses acts: **He chose then**, and you cannot ask why someone with free will chose when he did

A participant objected that Rav Saadia compares God to humans **when it suits him**. "That's a very good question. I agree with you. To be honest, I don't like that answer at all. I find it very, very difficult to describe

Hashem as a ***ba'al bechirah***, one who chooses. **I think the first answer answers it all**: there's no time, so you can't ask the question."

Essay 1 Complete

נשלם המאמר הראשון.

The position of Rav Saadia, "basically accepted by all Jewish philosophers and authorities": **Hashem created the world from nothing.** He refuted the alternatives and answered the questions. "Most of the things here we already knew and believe as Jewish people. In Essay 2 and Essay 3 there are more novel things. Here we've been establishing that there is a Creator and a creation."

Summary

1. **Question 1:** *the earth stands forever* means only **relatively** constant. **Question 2:** how He creates from nothing is beyond us; if we knew, we would be the Creator.
2. **Question 3, space:** place is where bodies meet; before creation there is no place. **הוא מקומו של עולם ואין עולמו מקומו; מקום = 186 = the Name squared**, and why we comfort mourners with *HaMakom*.
3. **Question 4, time:** time is a creation, relative to what is in it. No "before."
4. **Questions 5-6:** Hashem made as much as we can grasp (and science keeps showing us more); and He made **all** of it.
5. **Question 7, 4,693 years (933 CE):** a beginning is a beginning, whenever it was. The Rabbi on **old-universe questions**: Adam as **the completed human** who receives the *nishmat chayim* and free choice.
6. **Question 8:** not creating was not an "act" of refusing: human categories do not apply.
7. **Question 9, why create? No purpose we can ask about** (Rav Saadia's first answer, and the **Rambam, Moreh 3:13**); **to show His wisdom**; **for the good of His creatures**, developed by **the Ramchal**: the good wants to bestow good.
8. **Question 10, why then?** No time with God; and a chooser chooses. The Rabbi prefers the first.

Coming Up

No shiur next week (the Rabbi is officiating at a wedding on the bank holiday). The class resumes **in two weeks with Essay 2**, on **the unity of God**. *Chazak u'varuch.*

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